

Church of Hallgrímur

Iceland's largest church and tallest building and an Expressionist reflection of national pride



The Church of Hallgrímur, or Hallgrímskirkja, is a Lutheran church in Reykjavik, Iceland. Named after the Icelandic poet and clergyman Hallgrímur Pétursson (1614–1674), the church was an expression of national pride. It was designed by Guðjón Samúelsson in 1937, a state architect tasked with creating a distinctive Icelandic style of architecture that would reflect the country's extraordinary landscape. Begun in 1945, the church was finally completed in 1974. The result was a theatrical, Expressionist assemblage of white concrete columns, which together echo the symmetrical, conical form of Kirkjufell Mountain.

In the minimal interior, the arrangement of the 5,275 pipes of the church's large organ recalls the concrete columns of the exterior. Hallgrímur's central tower and spire reaches a height of 244 ft (74.5 m).

Unusual floor plan

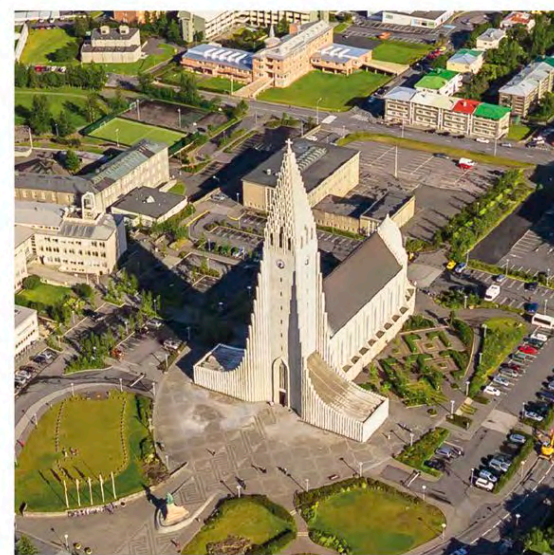
Samúelsson abandoned the cruciform shape of traditional churches and moved the side chapels into the wings on either side of the tower. The rectangular nave is lined with slender Gothic columns that support an unadorned rib vault and lead to the organ. The organ screens the nave and choir from the semicircular apse.

▷ LUTHERAN CATHEDRAL

The Lutheran Church of Hallgrímur dominates the city of Reykjavik and is visible from a distance of more than 12 miles (20 km). Its enormous tower provides views across the city to the mountains.

◁ GRAND ENTRANCE

The simple but dramatic tower on the west facade serves as the church's entrance. The entire building is built of concrete and is coated with a layer of coarse plaster and white granite for protection against the elements.



The church's **nave** was **consecrated in 1986**, the **bicentennial** of **Reykjavik's** founding